

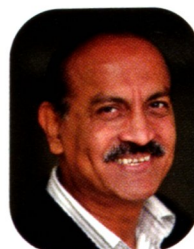
The Bonn Subversion

After 12 days of talks among delegates from 182 countries at the UN Climate Conference in Bonn which ended on June 12, the world seemed no closer to staving off the threat of global warming and its catastrophic consequences. What was needed was a firm commitment from developed countries to agree to significant reductions in their carbon emissions and a pledge to provide technology and finance to help developing countries mitigate and adapt to the ill-effects of climate change. What the world got instead was a rambling, hold-all, long-term cooperative action plan that ran into 200 pages with all the nations just putting down their wishlists. In the next six months leading up to the key conference in Copenhagen in December, negotiators would have the contentious task of hammering it down to a comprehensive, balanced and equitable charter to pull the earth back from the brink.

It's a tall order given the ambivalence of the developed countries to commit to any kind of substantial funding to help poorer countries combat climate change. At Bonn, India and other countries adopted a 'show us the money' approach: they pressed developed countries to commit to 0.5 to 1 per cent of their GDP that would release \$250 billion annually in adaptation and mitigation funds. Developed countries in turn demanded that major developing countries like China, India and Brazil commit to quantitative emission cuts before they make any such commitment. Worse, as India's chief negotiator Shyam Saran points out, developed countries also wanted full scrutiny of the way developing countries ran their economies—a kind of supranational authority—to monitor the use of such funds. Developing countries indignantly told the rich nations to take a hike.

On the other major issue of getting developed countries to agree to significant emission reductions to meet the second commitment period of the Kyoto Protocol that commences by 2013, hardly any progress was made. Most developed countries have not met the first commitment period that began in 2008 to reduce their overall emission of green-

house gases by at least 5 per cent below their 1990 levels. Despite US President Barack Obama's positive assertions, disappointingly there appears to be no fundamental change in the attitude of America, the world's biggest emitter of such gases. The US continues to drag its feet on emission commitments and play spoilsport at major meets. India and 36 other developing countries have demanded that developed countries as a group commit to cut their emissions by 40 per cent below 1990 levels by 2020 if the earth is to be saved. Sadly, the Bonn conference belied all hopes.



APPOINTED: Gopal Subramaniam, senior advocate in the Supreme Court, as the solicitor-general. He was the additional solicitor-general during 2005-09. He was

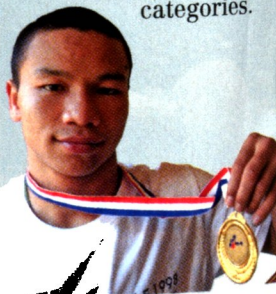


the counsel for the Justice K. Venkataswami Inquiry Commission that probed the Tehelka tapes exposing corruption.

ORDAINED: Mother Petra, founder of the Deena Sevana Sabha for destitutes, as a servant of God, the first step for canonisation as a saint under the Roman Catholic Church. She died in 1976.

WON: By Sukhen Dey, a bronze medal at the World Junior Weightlifting championships in Bucharest. He is the first Indian lifter in decades to win a medal at a world event.

WON: By Suranjoy Singh, a gold medal at the Asian Boxing Championships, at Zhuahai, China. Nanao Singh and Jai Bhagwan won silver medals in two categories.



SAURABH SINGH